MAJOR MOVES · VOLUME ONE

You Are the System

Major Dream Williams

If everything stops when you stop — what exactly have you built?

A Word from Major

[MAJOR'S WORDS] · *from Q1–Q3 · ~600 words · approval required*

I never think I'm the bottleneck in the business. These are my ideas.

But I realised it at a dinner party in Old San Juan. I'd invited about twelve people. Eighteen came. Someone had offered to cook — she was good, and she wanted to help. I was hosting.

It was a beautiful affair. The food was good. And at the end, the billing wasn't.

People showed up who hadn't confirmed, so we hadn't prepaid. I ran out of plates. We ran out of wine. I went to the local supermarket and I didn't have enough money, so I bought a bunch of cheaper wine — which was noticed.

Here's the part that took me longer to see. The problem wasn't the planning. It was that my pride kicked in. Rather than charging people, I wanted it to feel like I was just hosting, being benevolent. And none of these people were broke. They had money. I just didn't want to be the guy asking for it.

That cut the experience. Because even when you're being generous, even when you're giving people things — people only remember the moment when things aren't right. That's what sticks. You'll get a *yo, this was good*. You won't get repeat business.

And everything in that room ran through me. Nobody could look at a situation and just solve it, because the answer was always *well, this is Major's thing, let me ask Major.*

That's what a bottleneck is. By the definition, the neck of a bottle is the slimmest part for what's in the bottle. When it gets to

that slim part, everything slows down.

I've done the same thing outside of business. I was in a play once, with real actors, A-list people. I missed a cue and said the wrong line — close enough to another line that they heard it and just went with it, and it moved the play about ten minutes ahead. Very noticeable. Five weeks before that, I'd done it flawlessly. That's the thing. When you know you can do something, sometimes you get lazy with it. Sometimes you get undisciplined.

So if you aren't feeling good, or you're not in the right frame of mind, you will always be the thing that short-changes your own growth. And it sucks when you figure out that it's yourself.

Here's what I'd say now. The goal for any business isn't to be the reason the business succeeds — especially if you're the owner. It's to bring in people who are better than you and put them together so the thing can succeed without you standing in the middle of it.

I'll tell you plainly: this is something I still struggle with. It's not fully solved. I live in a world where we talk about the one-person billion-dollar company, and I still want that, because working with other people has been disappointing in a lot of ways. There's friction. There's tension. People don't see it the way you see it. And it makes you say — you know what, I'll do it myself. I've been disappointed too much. I'll do it myself.

And that's how you *willingly* become the bottleneck. As long as you're involved, at least it gets done, or at least it's done the way you want.

So this book isn't me on the other side of the problem telling you how I got out. It's me in it, showing you what I've learned about the shape of it. If you're the slim part of your own bottle, you're in good company. The question is whether you know it yet.

Chapter 1 — The Hidden Bottleneck

Most founders think they have a time problem.

They say it in the language of hours: *I need more time, I need another pair of hands, if the day were longer I'd be fine.* They buy planners. They wake earlier. They get ruthless with their calendar.

And none of it works for long, because it isn't a time problem. It's a structure problem.

There is a difference between being **busy** and being **load-bearing**. Busy means your day is full. Load-bearing means the thing falls down if you step away. You can be busy and replaceable. You can also be load-bearing and look, from the outside, like you're barely doing anything — until the week you get sick, and everything stops.

A bottleneck isn't a flaw in your effort. It's a feature of your architecture. You built a structure where every decision has to pass through one opening, and that opening is you.

The cruel part is that it feels like competence. People come to you because you're good. You answer because you're fast. Every time you solve something personally, you confirm that you're the right person to solve it — and you make the opening narrower.

Why we stay there

Three reasons, and none of them are laziness.

Fear of success. If this works, more people come. More people means more demand, more exposure, more of everything you're not sure you can carry. Slowing it down feels like prudence. It isn't.

Control, earned honestly. This is the one nobody admits. You've been let down. You handed something over and it came back wrong, or late, or not at all. So you took it back. That's not a character flaw — it's a scar. But a scar that makes you do everything yourself has a cost, and the cost is everything you can't build.

Atrophy. This is the quiet one. Nothing is going wrong. You aren't in crisis. You're simply the only source of oxygen in the room, and the room is getting smaller.

[MAJOR'S WORDS] · *Field Note · approval required*

> *Sometimes being the bottleneck feels safe, because you're slowing things down. But you don't realise it's really atrophy. It's not this idea of oh, I wish things were smoother. It's actually that there's a lack of oxygen.*
>
> *And it's not something you figure out and you're done with. You try to find that medium where you're working hard enough and benefiting the maximum you can for the effort you put in. But that's not the way this thing works. You have to put in more effort to give yourself enough room to then fix the system — which may be hiring more people, refining your ICP, or charging more. Versus just charging enough to barely cover. And sometimes you end up losing money.*

Exercise — The Dependency Score

Not a reflection. A list.

Write down the **last ten things that only you could do.** Not things you chose to do — things that genuinely could not have happened without you. Go back through last week's messages if you need to.

Score each one:

Score	Meaning
1	Someone else could do this tomorrow with a short explanation
2	Someone else could do this with training, or written instructions
3	Only you. It lives in your head, your relationships, or your judgment

Add them up.

Total	What it means
10–15	You have a delegation habit. Build on it.
16–23	You are load-bearing in places you haven't noticed.
24–30	You *are* the business. Everything in this book is urgent for you.

Keep this list. Chapter 4 comes back for it.

The honest part: most people score higher than they expect, and the first reaction is to justify the threes. *That one really does need me.* Maybe. Write down why — in one sentence, specifically. If the sentence is "because I'm faster," that's a two.

Chapter 2 — You Are the Process

Here is the thing about what lives only in your head: it isn't expertise. It's risk.

Knowledge that has never been written down can't be improved, because nobody can see it to question it. It can't be delegated, because there's nothing to hand over. It can't be sold, because a buyer is buying you, and you aren't for sale. And it can't be inherited.

You know how to do the thing. That's real. But *knowing how* and *having a process* are different states, and the gap between them is where most businesses quietly stall.

> [MAJOR'S WORDS]
>
> *When you want to automate something, you have to itemise everything that you do.*

That sentence is the whole chapter.

Itemising is uncomfortable because it exposes how much of your work is improvisation wearing the costume of expertise. You'll write out seven steps and realise that step four is actually *"and then I look at it and I know."* That's the step that matters. That's also the one you've never examined.

Why most founders skip this

Because writing it down feels slower than doing it. It is slower — once. Then it's faster forever, and it's the only version of the work

that can exist without you in the room.

There's also a quieter reason. If you write down what you do, you might find out it isn't that complicated. A lot of people would rather stay mysterious than find out they're replaceable. But being replaceable in your *tasks* is the only way to become irreplaceable in your *judgment* — and judgment is the part worth keeping.

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

> *Most of us do things effortlessly and don't realise that not everybody else can do these things.*

Both halves matter. What's effortless to you is genuinely valuable — and it's invisible to you *because* it's effortless. Itemising is how you find it.

Exercise — The System Audit

Pick **one** repeated task. Not the biggest. One you did this week and will do again next week.

Write it as numbered steps, as if handing it to someone capable who has never seen it.

Then go back through and mark every place you **improvised** — made a judgment call, checked something that wasn't on the list, decided it "felt off."

Column	What goes in it
Step	What happens
Input	What you need before you can do it
Output	What exists afterwards that didn't before
Improvisation	Where you used judgment instead of a rule

Handoff owner	A person, an agent, or *me, for now*

Your improvisation points are not failures of the system. They are the system's frontier. Each one is either a rule you haven't written yet, or genuine judgment that should stay with you. Deciding which is which is the actual work.

Chapter 3 — Time Is Not Scalable

Every growth plan priced in your hours has a ceiling, and you can calculate it. Most people never do, because the number is unpleasant and vague feels better.

Let's make it unpleasant and specific.

The calculation

Step one — your real hours. Not your working hours. The hours you can do the high-value, only-you work. For most people this is three to five a day, not eight. Be honest; a tired hour isn't a working hour.

Step two — your real weeks. Not 52. Subtract holidays, illness, travel, the weeks that quietly disappear. Most people get 44 to 46. If you've never taken a holiday, use 48 and notice what that tells you.

Step three — your rate. What someone actually pays for an hour of you.

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real hours/day × days/week × real weeks × rate = your ceiling
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That number is the maximum your business can earn while it is made of you. Not your target. Your **ceiling** — the wall you hit while doing everything right.

What the number actually tells you

If your ambition is above that line, you don't have an effort problem. You have an arithmetic problem, and no amount of waking up earlier solves arithmetic.

There are only three ways past it:

1. **Raise the rate** — fewer hours, higher value. Works until the market says no.
2. **Add people** — more hours that aren't yours. Works until you become the bottleneck

   for *them*, which is Chapter 1 arriving at a bigger scale.
3. **Stop selling hours** — build something that produces value while you are asleep. A

   system, a product, an agent.

Only the third one changes the shape of the ceiling. The other two raise it.

> [MAJOR'S WORDS]
>
> *You yourself, you're not scalable. There's not two, three of you.*

Exercise — Your Time Ceiling

Run the calculation. Write the number down. Then write your revenue goal underneath it.

If the goal is bigger than the ceiling — and it almost always is — write one sentence naming which of the three routes you're actually taking. Not which one you like. Which one you're taking.

Most people discover they've been assuming route one while behaving like route two and hoping for route three.

Chapter 4 — Build Systems, Not Heroics

Heroics get rewarded. That's the trap.

You stay up, you save the launch, you catch the mistake at midnight. People thank you. Someone says *we'd be lost without you.* It feels like proof that you matter.

It's proof that the structure is fragile.

A system that runs at 80% without you beats a performance that runs at 100% with you — because the first one compounds and the second one has a body attached to it. Your 100% has a bad week in it somewhere. The 80% doesn't care how you slept.

[MAJOR'S WORDS] · *Field Note · approval required*

> *You're not really knowing that it's a wooden boat and there's holes in the boat. There were termites eating the wood. Now you've got holes in the boat, and with every hole you're plugging it up, and it's just you on the boat — because this is your baby. Versus telling your crew: all right, plug that, plug that, plug that. Or, how do we fix that? You know what, get some caulk, get some sealant.*
>
> *You see a problem, you're on it. You see a problem, you're on it. You see a problem, you're on it. And then no problem gets fixed, because you're on them as they pop up. And before you know it, too many holes, and your business ends up failing.*

Read that again and notice what's missing: at no point is the founder doing anything wrong. He sees a problem and fixes it. Every single response is correct. The boat still sinks.

That's the difference between heroics and systems. Heroics are a sequence of correct responses to symptoms. A system asks what's eating the wood.

What conventional advice gets wrong

The instruction is *work harder*, and it is given by people for whom it worked once.

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

> *Most people think that they own a business, but you actually own a job that you're shackled to.*
>
> *Conventional business — you hire workers, you build a product, you open a storefront on a busy street. Location, location, location. You're signing leases for many, many years. You're trying to get traffic. You're hiring physical people, managing personalities, dynamics, theft, holidays, utilities, bills. Bank loans. You need a money source that gives you a runway — one, two, three years before you can be profitable, because you have to make all of that money back.*
>
> *And a lot of times the entrepreneur bears that whole load, because you've taken the money, you've had the idea, you're the face of the business. You can't take holidays. For somebody like me, who values their freedom, conventional business is the antithesis of freedom.*

There's a second thing it gets wrong, and it's more personal.

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

> *I feel that comes from being an athlete. Going hard, running harder, jumping higher, moving faster — all of these types of things kind of crept over to my entrepreneurial life. Versus measuring three times and cutting once.*

Effort is a real skill. It's just not the only one, and it's the one that transfers worst. In sport the feedback loop is tight: you run harder, you get faster. In business you can run harder in the wrong direction for two years and the only feedback is exhaustion.

Double down on what is actually happening

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

> *You wanted to be a fine dining restaurant. You realise people are really coming at lunch. You realise people are really just doing takeaway orders. So what do you do? You double and triple down on lunchtime takeaway. Get a smaller place, build an online app, create a ghost kitchen — something that accentuates what is really working. Versus trying to make the world see what you see.*
>
> *Nobody will see what you see. Nobody cares what you see. The only thing people care about is: how does it fix my problem. I'm not coming here to solve the fact that you want a fine dining restaurant. I want a sandwich at lunch. I want rice and peas and curry chicken at lunchtime. That's what I want, and I want to take it away and eat at my desk.*

The hardest sentence in this book is *nobody cares what you see.* It isn't cynicism. It's the release. The moment you stop defending your vision, you can start reading your evidence — and the evidence is already in your calendar, your inbox and your bank statement, telling you what people actually come to you for.

That's usually not what you put on the sign.

Exercise — Replace Yourself

Go back to your Dependency Score from Chapter 1. Take the item with the **lowest** score — the easiest thing to hand off.

Not the most painful. The easiest. You are practising the handoff, not performing surgery.

Write the brief:

- **The task** — in one sentence
- **The trigger** — what causes it to need doing
- **The input** — what they need in hand before starting
- **The steps** — from your System Audit
- **What "done" looks like** — specifically enough to check
- **The failure mode** — what going wrong looks like, and who gets told
- **Who** — a person, or an agent

Then hand it over. Actually hand it over.

The first one will come back imperfect. That's data about your brief, not about them.

Chapter 5 — Becoming the Architect

An operator does the work. An architect decides what work exists.

The shift isn't about status, and it isn't about doing less. It's about what you are to the structure. The operator is inside the thing, holding it up. The architect is the reason it stands without being held.

Most people get stuck on the way because the operator work is legible — you can see what you did today — and architecture is not. A week spent designing a system looks, from the outside and sometimes from the inside, like a week where nothing happened.

Why a system is bankable

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

There's nothing like having a system. Your system is what saves you. Period, point blank.

Michael Jordan won because he was a great basketball player. Yes. However — the triangle offense.

A recipe is a system. I can put one ounce of this, one ounce of this, eight ounces of this and two teaspoons of this, and it will come out every time. That's what people want. Systems bring consistency. People bank on consistency.

If you have no system, what are you grading on? Just what you feel? You can't do that. You can do it if you have enough money to make tons of mistakes — but most people's

margins are slim.

Four things a system gives you that effort never will:

Predictability	**the same input produces the same output, like a recipe**
Scalability	it runs without being you
Data	it produces numbers, so you can decide instead of guess
Longevity	it outlives your energy, and it can be cloned or sold

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

A system can bring longevity. If you put a system together, you can clone it and sell it. People buy systems. P90X was a fitness system that said: if you follow this, you will change your body in 90 days. And it worked, and people did it. You believe when you see results.

Notice what P90X sold. Not equipment. Not a gym. A **sequence**, with a promise attached to following it. The product was the system itself.

Ask the uncomfortable version of that question about your own business: if someone wanted to buy what you do — not your time, the thing itself — what exactly would you hand them?

If the answer is "they'd have to hire me," you haven't built it yet.

The honest limit of all this

A book that tells you to build systems owes you the place where systems cost something.

[MAJOR'S WORDS] · *The Question I Still Carry · approval required*

> *AI changes your need for awareness. It can make you not be aware. You can just take what your AI tells you. Now you have to actually be more aware, and more discerning.*

Systematise your hands and you get free. Systematise your **thinking** and you can stop thinking — and you won't notice, because the output still arrives on time and looks right.

The second danger is subtler. A system is an answer to a question you asked once. The market doesn't stand still, and a system that is working beautifully is the hardest thing to look at critically, because why would you.

[MAJOR'S WORDS]

> *Know your surroundings. Always be aware. Keep your head on a swivel. If you're not aware, it doesn't matter what your belief is. You can have as much belief as you want, but if it's in the wrong place, it's in the wrong place.*
>
> *Most business owners are so in the weeds, they aren't aware that gas prices are up and the best thing on my menu, I have to increase the price.*

So the architect's job doesn't end when the system runs. It changes: from building the thing to watching whether the thing still answers the question.

Try This Today

Build **one AI employee** that performs a single task from your Dependency Score.

One task. Not a department. The one you wrote the Replace Yourself brief for.

- **Input** — what it receives
- **Output** — what it produces, and where that lands
- **Failure mode** — how you'll know it got it wrong
- **Review cadence** — when you check it, and what you check

Then do the thing that separates a system from a hope: **watch it run once, end to end, before you trust it.** Not the configuration. The actual result, arriving where it's meant to arrive.

A system nobody has watched reach its destination is not yet a system.

Closing — The Question to Carry

[MAJOR'S WORDS] · *approval required*

I'm not going to leave you with a method. Methods are in the chapters.

I'll leave you with the question I ask, almost every day, usually of a machine now, which is its own kind of joke:

> ***What blind spots are we not looking at? What am I missing?***

That's it. That's the whole thing.

Because here's what I've found. The bottleneck is never where you're looking. If you could see it, you'd have fixed it already — you're capable, that's not the issue. It's sitting exactly where you don't look, and the reason you don't look there is usually that it's where your pride lives. Mine was at a dinner party in Old San Juan, in the decision not to charge people who could easily have paid.

You're going to have two choices in life. Either you're going to take the safe path, or you're going to have a great story.

And the more perspective you have, the more awareness you have.

Ask the question this week. Ask it out loud, of someone who'll answer honestly. Then go and look where they point, even though you don't want to.

Where to go next

Build your first AI employee. One task, off your Dependency Score, running by Friday.

[CTA into the MAIM ecosystem · Academy cohort · the newsletter] [Approved logo lockup · author portrait · bio]

Workbook

1 · Dependency Score sheet

#	The task — only you could do it	1 / 2 / 3	Why, in one sentence
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

Total: ____ / 30 · 10–15 delegating · 16–23 load-bearing in places · 24–30 you are the business

2 · System Audit template

Task: _____ Frequency: _____

#	Step	Input	Output	Improvised?	Handoff owner
1					

2
3
4
5

Improvisation points found: ____ For each one: is this a rule I haven't written, or judgment that stays with me?

3 · Time Ceiling calculator

Real high-value hours per day
Days per week
Real working weeks per year
Rate per hour
Ceiling
My revenue goal
Gap

Which route am I actually taking? ■ raise the rate ■ add people ■ stop selling hours

4 · Replace Yourself brief

Task
Trigger
Input needed
Steps
Definition of done

Failure mode, and who is told
Owner — person or agent
Handed over on
First result reviewed on

5 · First AI Employee spec

The single task
Input it receives
Output it produces
Where the output lands
How I'll know it failed
Review cadence
Watched run end-to-end on

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